PAW & FOUND



Pet First Aid

What to Do Before You Reach the Vet

A calm, practical emergency reference for pet owners.

6 essential sections | Wounds • Choking • Poisoning • Heatstroke • Seizures

Print this. Keep it with your first aid kit.

Before You Begin

This guide is a **practical emergency reference** — not a substitute for veterinary care. It's designed to help you take the right actions in the critical minutes before you reach professional help.

In any emergency, your first priority is to **stay calm**. Your pet will pick up on your stress. Take a deep breath, assess the situation, and follow the steps for your specific situation.

Every section includes clear warning signs, step-by-step actions, and a **"When to Go to the Vet NOW"** callout — because knowing when to act is just as important as knowing what to do.

🚨 **Save These Numbers Now**

ASPCA Animal Poison Control: **(888) 426-4435**

Pet Poison Helpline: **(855) 764-7661**

Your Vet's Emergency Number: _____

Nearest 24-Hour Emergency Clinic: _____

Section 1

Build Your Pet First Aid Kit

A well-stocked kit turns panic into action. Keep one at home and a smaller version in your car. Check and restock every 6 months.

- ☐ **Gauze pads & rolls**
  For wrapping wounds & controlling bleeding
- ☐ **Self-adhering bandage wrap**
  (Vetrap) — sticks to itself, not fur
- ☐ **Adhesive tape**
  Medical tape for securing bandages
- ☐ **Blunt-tip scissors**
  For cutting bandages near skin safely
- ☐ **Digital thermometer**
  Normal: 100–102.5°F (dog), 100.5–102.5°F (cat)
- ☐ **Tweezers**
  For removing splinters, ticks, debris
- ☐ **Saline eye wash**
  For flushing eyes or cleaning wounds
- ☐ **Antiseptic wipes**
  Alcohol-free; chlorhexidine or povidone-iodine
- ☐ **Disposable gloves**
  Protect yourself and your pet
- ☐ **Muzzle or soft restraint**
  Even gentle pets may bite when in pain
- ☐ **Towel or blanket**
  For warmth, transport, or restraint
- ☐ **Hydrogen peroxide 3%**
  ONLY for inducing vomiting when directed by a vet
- ☐ **Pet carrier**
  For safe transport of cats and small dogs
- ☐ **Emergency phone numbers**
  Vet, ER clinic, poison control

> **Pro tip:** Use a waterproof, clearly labeled container. Store it where everyone in the household knows — not buried in a closet.

Section 2

Wounds & Bleeding

⚠️ WARNING SIGNS

- Blood spurting (arterial — very serious)
- Bleeding that doesn't slow after 10 min of pressure
- Deep puncture wounds or large gashes
- Pale gums, weakness, or collapse (shock)
- Wound near eyes, chest, or abdomen

🏥 GO TO THE VET NOW IF:

Bleeding is heavy or won't stop after 10 minutes of direct pressure. The wound is deep, large, or near a vital area. Your pet shows signs of shock (pale gums, rapid breathing, weakness). Any bite wound from another animal — infection risk is high.

📝 Emergency Actions

1. **RESTRAIN SAFELY**
   Even the sweetest pet may bite when hurt. Use a muzzle if needed — but **never** muzzle a pet that is vomiting, choking, or having trouble breathing.
2. **APPLY DIRECT PRESSURE**
   Use a clean gauze pad, cloth, or towel. Press firmly on the wound for **5–10 minutes** without lifting to check. Lifting disrupts clotting.
3. **IF BLOOD SOAKS THROUGH**
   Add more gauze on top — don't remove the original layer. Removing it tears away the clot.
4. **ELEVATE IF POSSIBLE**
   If the wound is on a limb and there's no fracture, gently raise it above heart level to slow bleeding.
5. **CLEAN MINOR WOUNDS**
   Once bleeding is controlled, flush with saline or clean water. Apply antiseptic (chlorhexidine, not alcohol). Cover with a non-stick pad and wrap with bandage.
6. **WATCH FOR INFECTION**
   Check the wound daily. Redness, swelling, warmth, pus, or odor = vet visit.

> ⚠️ **Do NOT:** use hydrogen peroxide on open wounds (damages tissue). Do NOT apply tourniquets unless a vet instructs you — they can cause permanent damage.

Section 3

Choking

⚠️ WARNING SIGNS

- Pawing at the mouth or face
- Gagging, retching, or coughing forcefully
- Difficulty breathing or noisy breathing
- Blue-tinged gums or tongue (cyanosis)
- Panic, pacing, or collapse
- Unable to make any sound (complete blockage)

🏥 GO TO THE VET NOW IF:

Your pet collapses or loses consciousness. The object can't be removed after 1–2 attempts. Breathing doesn't return to normal after the object is cleared (there may be throat damage).

📝 Emergency Actions

1. **STAY CALM — ASSESS**

   Is your pet coughing? If they can cough, let them — coughing is the body's way of clearing the airway. Intervene only if they stop coughing and can't breathe.

2. **CHECK THE MOUTH**

   Gently open the mouth and look inside. Use a flashlight. If you can see the object, try to remove it with tweezers or fingers — **be careful not to push it deeper**. Be prepared to be bitten.

3. **FOR DOGS: HEIMLICH MANEUVER**

   Stand behind your dog (for small dogs, kneel). Make a fist and place it in the soft hollow just behind the ribcage. Thrust inward and upward firmly 4–5 times.

4. **FOR CATS & SMALL DOGS: ALTERNATE METHOD**

   Hold the pet with their back against your chest. Place your fist below the ribcage and thrust inward/upward. Or, hold them by the thighs and swing gently downward — gravity can help.

5. **CHECK AGAIN**

   After each attempt, check the mouth. The object may have dislodged. Remove if visible.

6. **IF YOUR PET COLLAPSES**

   Start CPR on the way to the vet: 30 chest compressions, then 2 rescue breaths (close the mouth and breathe into the nose).

> ⚠️ **Do NOT:** blindly sweep the back of the throat with your finger — you may push the object deeper. Do NOT perform CPR on a conscious pet.

Section 4

Poisoning & Toxins

⚠️ WARNING SIGNS

- Vomiting or diarrhea (may contain blood)
- Drooling excessively or foaming at the mouth
- Seizures, tremors, or muscle twitching
- Lethargy, weakness, or collapse
- Pale or yellow gums
- Loss of coordination (drunken gait)

🏥 GO TO THE VET NOW IF:

Any suspected poisoning is an emergency. If you know or suspect your pet ingested a toxin, call poison control immediately, then go to the vet. Bring the container/label of what was eaten.

📝 Emergency Actions

1. **IDENTIFY THE TOXIN**

   What did they eat? How much? When? Find the packaging, label, or plant. Count remaining pills or chocolate. This information is critical for the vet.

2. **CALL POISON CONTROL FIRST**

   ASPCA Poison Control: **(888) 426-4435** or Pet Poison Helpline: **(855) 764-7661**. They'll tell you whether to induce vomiting or not — **do not do it without guidance.**

3. **DO NOT INDUCE VOMITING IF:**

   They ingested caustic substances (drain cleaner, bleach, battery acid), petroleum products (gasoline, kerosene), sharp objects, or if they're already vomiting, seizing, unconscious, or having trouble breathing.

4. **IF INSTRUCTED TO INDUCE VOMITING**

   Use **3% hydrogen peroxide only**: 1 teaspoon per 10 lbs of body weight (max 3 tablespoons). Give with a syringe or turkey baster. Walk them around — vomiting should occur within 10–15 minutes. If not, call the vet — do NOT repeat the dose.

5. **COLLECT A SAMPLE**

   Save any vomit for the vet to analyze. It may help identify the toxin.

☠️ Common Household Toxins:

- Chocolate (especially dark)
- Grapes & raisins
- Macadamia nuts
- Lilies (deadly to cats)
- Human medications
- Xylitol (sugar-free gum)
- Onions, garlic, chives
- Alcohol & caffeine
- Antifreeze (ethylene glycol)
- Rat poison / rodenticides

Section 5

Heatstroke

⚠️ WARNING SIGNS

- Excessive panting that doesn't slow down
- Bright red or dark red gums and tongue
- Thick, sticky saliva or drooling
- Vomiting or diarrhea (may be bloody)
- Staggering, weakness, or collapse
- Seizures or unresponsiveness

🏥 GO TO THE VET NOW IF:

Your pet's temperature is 104°F or above. They are vomiting, having diarrhea, staggering, seizing, or losing consciousness. Heatstroke causes organ damage quickly — even if they seem to recover, **still see a vet** for a full check.

📝 Emergency Actions

1. **MOVE TO SHADE OR A/C IMMEDIATELY**
   Get your pet out of the heat. Every minute counts.
2. **COOL GRADUALLY — NOT ICE COLD**
   Use **cool (not cold)** water. Apply to paws, ears, belly, and groin. Soak towels in cool water and place them on these areas. Do NOT use ice or ice-cold water — this constricts blood vessels and traps heat inside.
3. **OFFER SMALL SIPS OF WATER**
   Let them drink if they're conscious and able. Don't force water or pour it into the mouth — they may inhale it.
4. **USE A FAN**
   Point a fan at your pet while they're damp. Evaporation speeds cooling.
5. **CHECK TEMPERATURE**
   If you have a rectal thermometer, take their temperature every 5 minutes. Stop cooling when it reaches **103°F** — going lower risks hypothermia.
6. **TRANSPORT TO VET**
   Even if they seem to recover, heatstroke can cause internal damage that isn't immediately visible. Get them checked.

> **Prevention saves lives:** Never leave pets in a parked car — even with windows cracked. On a 75°F day, the inside of a car reaches 100°F in 10 minutes. Walk early or late in summer, and always bring water.

Section 6

Seizures

⚠️ WHAT A SEIZURE LOOKS LIKE

- Collapse and loss of consciousness
- Stiffening of legs and body (tonic phase)
- Paddling or jerking movements (clonic phase)
- Jaw chomping or tongue chewing
- Drooling, foaming at the mouth
- Loss of bladder or bowel control

🏥 GO TO THE VET NOW IF:

The seizure lasts **more than 5 minutes** (status epilepticus — life-threatening). Multiple seizures occur in a 24-hour period (cluster seizures). This is your pet's first seizure. Your pet doesn't fully recover between seizures. Your pet is a puppy, kitten, or has known toxin exposure.

📝 Emergency Actions

1. **STAY CALM — TIME IT**
   Note the time the seizure starts. Most seizures last **1–3 minutes**. It will feel like forever, but it will end.
2. **CLEAR THE AREA**
   Move furniture, objects, and other pets away. Your pet cannot control their movements and may injure themselves.
3. **PROTECT THEIR HEAD**
   Gently slide a folded towel or blanket under their head to cushion it. Do not restrain the body.
4. **DIM THE LIGHTS, REDUCE NOISE**
   Lower stimulation. Turn off TV, radio, bright lights. Speak in a calm, quiet voice.
5. **AFTER THE SEIZURE ENDS**
   Your pet will be disoriented, confused, and possibly temporarily blind. This post-ictal phase can last minutes to hours. Keep them in a safe, quiet space. Offer water but not food immediately.
6. **RECORD DETAILS FOR THE VET**
   How long did it last? What did it look like? What was your pet doing right before? This helps with diagnosis.

⚠️ **NEVER:** put your hand near the mouth — your pet cannot swallow their tongue, but they CAN accidentally bite you. Do NOT try to hold them down or stop the movements. Do NOT pour anything in their mouth.